

Design quality

Front fence to back fence

Sixteen questions about how a project will work for the people who live in it, walk past it and live next to it, asked in the order you would walk a lot. Each one is already tested somewhere in NSW planning, so we ask it early, before a design is drawn.

The street edge

Question	Where NSW already tests it
☐ 01 Does the building face the street with windows and a front door, rather than a garage wall?	Council DCP street-front controls; the NSW crime-prevention guidelines councils apply to DAs
☐ 02 Can cars get in and out without reversing blind across a busy footpath?	Council DCP driveway controls; Australian Standard AS/NZS 2890.1 for off-street parking
☐ 03 Is the site on a busy road or next to a rail line?	Transport and Infrastructure SEPP noise provisions and the NSW guideline for development near rail corridors and busy roads

Arriving

☐ 04 Can a visitor find the front door from the footpath, by day and at night?	Council DCP entry and street-address controls; the Apartment Design Guide for apartments
☐ 05 Do bins, letterboxes and meters have a place that doesn't take over the front garden?	Council DCP waste storage and front setback controls

The home

☐ 06 Do the main living rooms get winter sun?	Council DCP solar access controls; the Apartment Design Guide for apartments
☐ 07 Can air move through the home, with windows on more than one side?	The Apartment Design Guide's cross-ventilation targets; BASIX thermal comfort
☐ 08 Do windows have an outlook without looking straight into a neighbour's?	Council DCP visual privacy controls; Apartment Design Guide building separation

The backyard

☐ 09 Does every home get private open space it can use, straight off a living area?	Council DCP private open space controls; the complying development codes
☐ 10 Is there deep soil where a tree can grow to full size?	Council DCP deep soil and landscaped area controls; Apartment Design Guide deep soil zones

The neighbours

☐ 11 Will the neighbours keep their winter sun?	Council DCP overshadowing controls
☐ 12 Does the building step down or set back where it meets smaller houses next door?	LEP height of buildings; DCP setback and building envelope controls
☐ 13 Would the bulk sit comfortably in the street as it looks today?	LEP floor space ratio; DCP character and streetscape controls

Trees and the wider street

☐ 14 Can the existing trees be kept, especially street trees and trees near the boundaries?	Biodiversity and Conservation SEPP (vegetation in urban areas); council tree rules
☐ 15 Is there a park, school or local shops within a short walk?	Council open space maps; Greener Places
☐ 16 Is the site within walking distance of a station or town centre?	Low and Mid-Rise Housing Policy (800 m catchments); Transport Oriented Development controls

Part of every Feasibility & Strategy, Pre-Design Brief and DA / CDC Report.